spread concepts of freedom, modernisation and independence among the Afghans.[158] Habibullah himself had tried to regain control of Afghanistan's foreign affairs at the end of the First World War, to no avail.[159] Indeed, the desire for self-determination was one of the very reasons Amanullah had gone to war with India in the first place. For, as Vartan Gregorian explains, 'In 1919, no ruler could have succeeded in establishing a strong hold over the Afghan nation without pledging himself to the cause of total Afghan independence.'[160] From Delhi's point of view, the British Empire simply could not deal with its Asian neighbours as it had done before 1918. If the Indian delegation forced a provision regarding Afghanistan's foreign relations on Kabul, all that would happen was that the emir would break the terms anyway, leaving Britain in an awkward position, whereby it would be forced either to ignore this treaty violation or to resume hostilities in order to save face.[161]

Realising it could no longer use force to retain its predominance over Afghanistan, the Indian government instead hoped to be able to gain Afghan confidence and friendship to keep that country allied to Britain. As Hamilton Grant tried to explain to Sir George Roos-Keppel, chief commissioner of the North-West Frontier Province:

It is obviously imperative for us so far as possible to exclude this force [Bolshevism] from Afghanistan. We cannot do so by military measures... The only alternative appears to be to secure the genuine friendship and trust of Afghanistan, and to convince the Afghans of the danger of the inroad of Bolshevism.[162]

Roos-Keppel, who had led troops into battle during the Anglo-Afghan War, doubted that there had ever been 'any really friendly feeling among the Afghans towards the British Government and I do not think there will ever be. As regards mutual trust the past has shown that we can never trust Afghans.'[163] According to Chelmsford, however, Roos-Keppel 'is confessedly an Afghanphobe. He hates the Afghans and, I think I may say